

Afghanistan(/country/afg)

Afghanistan: Information management to play key role in aid work

News and Press Release

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Integrated Regional Information Network (IRIN)

ISLAMABAD, 9 January (IRIN) - The Afghanistan Information Management Service (AIMS) this week announced steps to enhance its support for the humanitarian community working in Afghanistan by various means, including a plan to open an office in the Afghan capital, Kabul.

AIMS - a joint venture between the office of the UN Humanitarian Coordinator for Afghanistan and the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) - comprises the Humanitarian Information Centre for Afghanistan and the Project Management Information System (ProMIS).

Whereas ProMIS was initiated in 1997 by UNDP and FAO (Food and Agriculture Organisation) to enhance the capacity of the UN agencies and the donor community to undertake analysis and planning for operational activities, the information centre was established in October 2001 to act as a central point for information resources, with the aim of reinforcing coordination and humanitarian-response activities, following the events of 11 September.

Paul Currion, the project manager, told IRIN on Wednesday that joining these two projects together was a logical step. AIMS was established to help the aid community to work more effectively, by way of providing tools and services in the field of information management.

"We also aim to support the new UN mission being set up in Afghanistan, and the new Afghan interim administration," Currion said.

The project now holds a large amount of data relating to a broad range of issues. One prominent data set is the Settlement Database, a comprehensive listing of settlements across Afghanistan, identifying locations with coordinates. This geo-referenced database builds on existing United States Defence Mapping Agency data with information from other international organisations working in Afghanistan.

The potential use of such a database is almost unlimited. It enables users to plan and execute aid projects,

plan on how and where to rebuild infrastructure, and even help the authorities to register people for voting.

"The Settlement Database is just one example of the principles that AIMS works by," said Currion. "Through building partnerships with other organisations, the project brings together diverse data and turns it into products that the entire assistance community can use in its work."

Currion said one of the greatest challenges facing the project was how to deliver services and products to the aid community, given security and accessibility constraints. One of the key tools the project will use is its newly redesigned web site, www.hic.org.pk(<http://www.hic.org.pk>), making data and information available to people outside the region.

"We are also introducing dynamic mapping tools, where people can go to the web site, pick the layers of information they need, and build their own maps," Currion explained.

Another way of overcoming the problem of disseminating information was by deploying AIMS staff inside Afghanistan, he said.

A new information centre will shortly be opening in Kabul (in addition to the one already existing in Islamabad), and field officers will be placed in support of the existing regional coordination structure, providing access to the AIMS service to those working in the field.

Due to years of war and instability, comprehensive and accurate data about people, villages, schools and health facilities is difficult to establish for Afghanistan. Lack of such information is a handicap for any group to plan and execute development projects. Thus, information-sharing will be extremely helpful to the massive reconstruction package being prepared by the international community after the rout of the Taliban in Afghanistan.

"This will lead to more accurate information reaching decision-makers quickly, creating a shared frame of reference enabling decision-makers to coordinate their activities," Currion said.

[ENDS]

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Other

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